Unit 13. How to preach a Bible passage (Action)

Overview

We have seen throughout that 2 Timothy emphasises the central place of the Bible (the words of God) and its gospel (the Word of God). It is essential that anyone who leads, teaches and cares for a congregation is able to "preach the Word" (2 Tim 4:2), as we have just seen in Unit 12.

This unit builds on that unit, but also on Unit 3, where you learnt how to discover the original message of a passage of Scripture, and is designed to provide steps to help you to preach or teach that message today.

These steps are essential to the BUILD curriculum and will be used throughout as we constantly move from texts to teaching those texts.

Outline

- Introducing expository preaching
- Completing the 'Scripture Sculpture' process
- The steps of preaching a passage applied to 2 Tim 1:6-7
  STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon
  STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon
  STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon
  STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon
- Conclusion: Pulling it all together

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain how Unit 13 relates to Unit 3
2. Outline the steps of preaching a passage of Scripture
3. Demonstrate how to follow the steps of preaching
4. Evaluate sermons using some simple steps

13.1 INTRODUCING EXPOSITORY PREACHING

13.1.1 Your own experience of preaching

- What are the components of a strong and effective sermon? Think back to some of the best preaching you have heard.

- What makes for a weak and poor sermon? Think back to some of the worst preaching you have heard.

13.1.2 What is expository preaching and why is it important?

- Discuss this question together. There are different kinds or types of sermon, can you think of any different sorts of sermon? What are the strengths and weaknesses of each?

Different types of preaching can have a place in the life of the church. But we have seen from the Pastoral Epistles that all preaching must be the explanation and application of Scripture, the Gospel, and Jesus Christ at the centre. This means that there is a foundational or fundamental type of preaching, which is often called **expository preaching**.

Some people think expository preaching is a style of preaching, one in which the preacher works through the verses in a passage systematically. Expository preaching might or might not involve that method, because expository preaching is not a style of preaching but is an approach to preaching. The word 'expository' describes the foundation, basis or underlying theory of preaching.

- How many sermons have you heard in which the preacher takes a verse of Scripture and then uses it as an opportunity to say whatever he wants to say?

The aim of expository preaching is to **expose** the message of a passage. It is based on a belief that the Bible is God's word and that God speaks through it. We need to simply allow the Bible to speak freely on its own terms, rather than to **impose** our own message on the passage and then on our people. The job of the preacher is simply to let the Bible to do the talking, and to trust that God will speak as he reveals and applies the message of the Bible to our lives today, by his Holy Spirit.

We must not impose our understanding on the Bible, but expository preaching does take the nature and purpose of the Bible into account. In units 9, 10 and 11 we saw the link between **Scripture**, **Salvation**, and the **Saviour**. Scripture has Salvation as its subject and the Saviour as its focus. Expository preaching follows this pattern: we must preach the Bible in the way the Bible is designed to be preached. That makes it a far more exciting and rewarding way to preach. It is like crafting a sculpture out of wood, and going with the grain of the wood rather than going against it, which is messy and hard work. And just as the master craftsman sees a design within the wood, we see God's design in the passage.

Another way of thinking about this is the link between 2 Timothy Chapter 3 and 2 Timothy Chapter 4. Chapter three ends with the Scriptures as the foundation for gospel ministry; Chapter four begins with the charge to preach the gospel. Paul assumes a link between the two – the gospel is preached and Christ is honoured as the Bible is taught.

This also means that expository preaching can evangelise those who are not Christians and encourage those who are – because it constantly teaches the gospel that saves us and which also builds us up. In other words evangelistic preaching is not simply one type of preaching for those who do not yet believe, and expository preaching is another sort for Christians. Expository preaching can be evangelistic, or encouraging, or both.

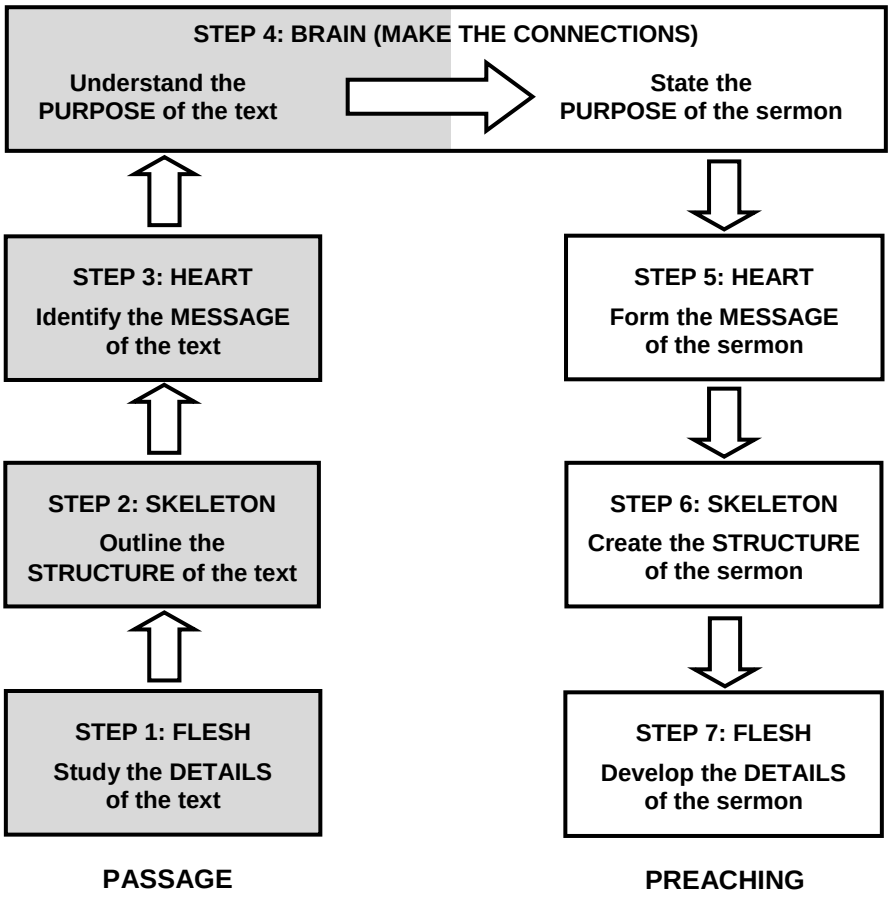
13.2 COMPLETING THE 'SCRIPTURE SCULPTURE' PROCESS

The 'Scripture Sculpture process', which we began to look at in Unit 4, helps us to prepare expository sermons. The process is called 'Scripture Sculpture' because understanding and preaching the Bible is an art: it is the process of taking what God has given us and using that to shape and influence every aspect of a sermon.

In Unit 4 we looked at the first steps of this process: how to **discover** what God has said to his people, a process which we called 'How to encounter a passage of the Bible'. In this unit we will complete the steps by looking at 'How to preach a passage of the Bible', and be able to **declare** what God is saying to his people today.

13.2.1 The seven steps of the Scripture Sculpture process

The whole Scripture Sculpture process is illustrated below, with the steps we have already used to encounter passages of the Pastoral Epistles shaded in grey:



This unit begins at the top of the diagram by extending Step 4 to form a bridge to connect with today's world. It then continues down the right hand side: from the BRAIN of the sermon to the HEART of the sermon to the SKELETON of the sermon to the FLESH of the sermon.

- Learn, memorise and explain the logic to someone else using these key words:

PASSAGE
flesh → skeleton → heart → brain → heart → skeleton → flesh
SERMON

13.2.2 A review of our encounter with 2 Tim 1:6-7

When we come to look at the four steps of preaching a passage of the Bible in detail we will use the same text we studied in Unit 4, which is 2 Tim 1:6-7. We need to review what we have learnt so far in Unit 4 when we encountered that text. This is what we discovered:

STEP 1: FLESH – Study the DETAILS of the text

In 2 Tim 1:6-7 we saw that:

- Paul is convinced that Timothy's faith in Christ is genuine.
- Because of this confidence Paul reminds Timothy to do something important. Timothy must renew his confidence in God and his gifts.
- The greatest gift of all is that of God's Holy Spirit with us. He is powerful, loving and self-disciplined.

STEP 2: SKELETON – Outline the STRUCTURE of the text

In 2 Tim 1:6-7 we noted:

1. The **introduction** to confidence in God and his gifts: Timothy can be confident in his faith (v. 6a) because Paul has already assured him it is "sincere" (v. 5).
2. The **command** to renew confidence in God and his gifts: Timothy can be confident that he has the God-given gifts for ministry, therefore he must rekindle them (v. 6b).
3. The **reason** to renew confidence in God and his gifts: God's Spirit is committed and resilient, and we have the presence of this confidence building Spirit in our lives (v. 7).

STEP 3: HEART – Identify the MESSAGE of the text

In 2 Tim 1:6-7 we discovered that:

- The theme is, Renewing confidence in God and his gifts for ministry.
- The message from Paul to Timothy is to renew his confidence in God and his gifts for ministry.

STEP 4: BRAIN – Understand the PURPOSE of the text

In 2 Tim 1:6-7 we realised that:

- Paul tells Timothy to renew his confidence in God and his gifts because he is facing an urgent and demanding task, one that he cannot overcome with his own abilities and strength.

We began to make connections and asked this question:

- In the face of all the daily demands and difficulties we face, how can we renew our confidence in God and his gifts for ministry?

13.2.3 The steps of preaching a Bible passage in outline

The table below gives the outcome of each main step, and also breaks that step down into manageable parts for you.

STEP 4: BRAIN – B) State the PURPOSE of the sermon At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the purpose of the sermon. You need to: a) Keep your **listeners** in mind b) Decide what God wants your people to **understand and obey** c) State the **purpose** of the sermon
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the message of the sermon in one or two sentences. You need to: a) State the **theme** of your sermon b) Build on that and state the **message** of your sermon c) **Check** that the message 'works' for your people today
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon At the end of this step you will have a clear outline for the sermon. You need to: a) Clarify the **main points** or structure of the sermon b) Create an **introduction** c) Develop the **body** d) Have an idea for the **conclusion**
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon At the end of this step you can preach the sermon to your people. You need to: a) Remember the importance of **words** b) Create **notes** that will help you to preach c) Use your **voice** to communicate d) Take care with **presentation** e) Remember the importance of **evaluation**

13.3 THE STEPS OF PREACHING A PASSAGE APPLIED TO 2 TIM 1:6-7

13.3.1 STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of your sermon to someone.

> **Remember:** The purpose statement acts as a bridge in the process of teaching the passage today. Once you know why the text is in the Bible – what it is there to achieve – you can develop a purpose for your sermon or teaching.

It is important to have a clear purpose for the sermon for a number of reasons. Adapting and building on Ramesh Richard:

- **The purpose** can help you to establish and form the sermon's heart.
- **The purpose** can help with the sermon's introduction.
- **The purpose** helps you decide what to include and what to leave out.
- **The purpose** guides the application and conclusion of the sermon.
- **The purpose** helps you to evaluate the sermon.
- **The purpose** gives you a sense of purpose as you preach the sermon.

We have already begun on this step because we have come to **understand the PURPOSE of the text**. In Unit 4 we discovered this purpose for 2 Tim 1:6-7:

- Paul tells Timothy to renew his confidence in God and his gifts because he is facing an urgent and demanding task, one that he cannot overcome with his own abilities and strength.

We took that a step further and began to **translate it into the PURPOSE of the sermon**. In Unit 4 we began to build a bridge and to make some connections with our own context today. That led to the purpose expressed as a question:

- In the face of all the daily demands and difficulties we face, how can we renew our confidence in God and his gifts for ministry?

That is a good general statement of purpose for a sermon based on 2 Tim 1:6-7. Because of the nature of 2 Timothy. But it will need to be tailored for most situations and congregations. You need to learn **how to create a purpose statement for your listeners**.

a) Keep your listeners in mind

We must keep our listeners in mind. Pray for your listeners in the light of the passage. We need to consider their needs and situations. Real sermons are not abstract lectures. As you learn to preach in the BUILD group that must also be the case. Think about a sermon you will preach on Sunday to your congregation. Or think about what you would say if you were to speak to your BUILD group: imagine that your fellow BUILD participants are your congregation.

b) Consider what God wants your listeners to know and obey

Ask and answer this question, in the light of the Bible passage: What does God want my listeners to know and obey?

As you do so, continue to reflect on the heart of the text, its theme and message. That theme was confidence for ministry. And the message to Timothy was that he can be confident that he has everything he needs for his ministry: the gifts of the Spirit and the gift of the Spirit. And it is vital to be guided by the brain of the text, its purpose, which is to renew confidence in God and his gifts for ministry.

It may help to complete these two statements:

> God wants my listeners to know this truth:…
>
> And, God wants my listeners to obey that truth in these ways:…

You can then combine those statements.

- Work together now on answering the question, What does God want my listeners to know and to obey?

c) State the purpose of the sermon

That statement comes from turning your answers above into a single statement, beginning with these words: “The purpose of my sermon is...”

- Turn your thinking into a single statement of your sermon’s purpose. Begin that statement with these words: “The purpose of my sermon is...”

CHURCH HEALTH WARNING: If you do not know what your sermon’s purpose is, DO NOT PREACH IT! In other words do not preach unless you know why you are preaching!

13.3.2 STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the theme and message of the sermon in one or two sentences.

> **Remember:** You can use the heart of the passage, together with the brain and connections you have begun to make, to form the heart of your sermon – the message or main point you will communicate.

a) State the theme of your sermon

This may well flow from the brain of the sermon. The theme of the sermon is simply your main point, the main thing you are talking about, your subject.

- Building on your purpose statement, what will you be talking about?

The theme can be given as a simple statement: 'How to keep going with gospel ministry.' Or it can be explored in the form of a question: 'How can we keep going with gospel ministry?'

b) Build on that and state the message of your sermon

The message of your sermon is what you will be saying about that theme. In other words, what will you be saying about what you are talking about?

- Can you develop a message from that theme, which is faithful to 2 Tim 1:6-7?

c) Check that the message 'works' for your people today

This means thinking a bit more about your audience and their situation. Think about the words: are they simple, clear and alive? Will the heart of my sermon get to the heart of this group of people? Is the message memorable?

- Rework and restate the message of the sermon if necessary.

13.3.3 STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will have a clear outline for the sermon.

> **Remember:** The purpose and message of your sermon will help you to create the structure of the sermon.
>
> This form may be different to the structure of the passage, but it will always draw on it and be guided by it.

a) Clarify the main points or structure of the sermon

The structure must serve the purpose, the message, the explanation of the passage and the audience. It can be informed by the passage, but remember that the structure of the passage was designed to communicate the message to the original audience and it may or may not be the best form for your people today.

The skeleton of the passage may provide a general guide. For example, when teaching proverbs, it might be appropriate to make some short memorable statements that work as proverbs for today. Or if you are looking at a biblical story, it might be appropriate to simply use the story, or a similar story, as a framework.

It might be that in the passage:

- There are 3 ideas you can use as a structure
- There are 2 questions it asks
- There are 4 steps it encourages people to take
- There is a contrast it makes that can shape your sermon
- There are 4 emotions it communicates
- There are 3 ways it makes the same point
- There is a puzzle to be solved – you can (1) state the puzzle, (2) solve the puzzle, (3) apply the puzzle and solution to our lives

- Can you list other possibilities?

- How would you structure a sermon on 2 Timothy 1:6-7? Give an outline below:

b) Develop the body

Developing the body of the talk often means thinking through how those points will be made. This usually means the following:

- Stating a point clearly
- Explaining a point simply
- Illustrating a point to shed light on it
- Applying a point to the lives of the listeners
- Linking that point on to the next one or into the conclusion

Good application is important, and will be guided by the message and purpose you have given the sermon. Preachers tend to give too little thought and time to this area. Prayer is important throughout sermon preparation, but it is particularly important when it comes to application. We will build on these areas throughout the curriculum but we must:

1) Encourage <u>repentance and faith</u>
The biblical pattern for transformation is through **repentance** and **faith**. That means turning away from sinful thoughts, words, deeds and habits, and turning to Christ and walking in his way. Both must be held together. Repentance without faith is moralistic. Faith without repentance is hollow.

We need to encourage people to turn away from wrong thinking and wrong living, and to embrace Christ's way. Encouraging them to embrace Christ's way must point them to the liberating message of the cross, and the encouraging presence and power of the Spirit.

2. Engage <u>mind, heart and will</u>
Applications can include challenges that change people's thinking. But they must also include ways of changing people's character and behaviour.

c) Create an introduction

An introduction grabs and holds the listeners attention, taking them from their world of distractions and concerns, and into the world of the Bible and the sermon. Therefore it should relate to both those worlds: the world of the listener and the world of the Bible.

- It might be a story that leads into the purpose of the sermon and the passage of the bible.

- It could be a question that is relevant to the listener and which the passage answers.

The BRAIN of the sermon will be particularly helpful here.

- What introduction might work for our sermon on 2 Tim 1:6-7?

d) Have an idea for the conclusion

A good conclusion is also important, and tends to be neglected. The conclusion takes the listener back into their world, and, when part of corporate worship, into the rest of the service.

- It might be a summary of the sermon, but it should not simply be that
- It might be a fresh twist that reinforces the point
- It might lead back to the introduction and build on that
- It might be a set of applications that lead to specific prayer or prayer ministry

- How would you conclude our sermon on 2 Tim 1:6-7?

13.3.4 STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon

At the end of this step you can preach the sermon to your people.

> **Remember:** You can finally put some flesh and skin on the bones and create the sermon. Ask God to breathe his Spirit into the message and you, his messenger.

a) Remember the importance of words

Preaching is more than words (what other aspects of communication are there?).

But preaching is never less than words, and the choice of words is important.

Think carefully about how you will put things as you flesh out the skeleton.

b) Create notes that will help you to preach

What sort of notes should you create to help you to deliver your sermon? People have different answers to this question.

No notes? ⟷ A full manuscript?

Some people say that you do not need any notes at all. People say that notes inhibit you. Others say that you should have a full manuscript.

The answer probably lies somewhere in between and you need to learn what works best for you. In practice the more work you put into this the *less* you will be inhibited.

NOTE: People also think that it is easy to give a short talk. But the shorter the talk is the more time you will need to give to preparing notes for every minute that you speak.

c) Use your voice to communicate

Good use of your voice is not about *volume* but *variety*. Remember to vary and use these four words:

- Pitch (vary the tone of your voice)
- Pace (vary the speed of your delivery)
- Pause (stop speaking for a moment or two to give space for thought)
- Power (vary the intensity and volume)

Trainers need to explain and demonstrate this. Explain that a culture of shouting can hinder real communication and learning.

d) Take care with presentation

Be yourself but think how you will best serve the listeners.

Practice your preaching. Some people think that this is 'unspiritual'. But time given to going over your message and praying over your message will give you more confidence and freedom. Become familiar with your sermon and remember to preach it to yourself first.

e) Do not forget the importance of evaluation

A simple form of evaluation is to use the questions:

Was the sermon TRUE?	Did the **message** come from the Bible? Was it true to the text and to the gospel? Was it God's word?
Was the sermon RELEVANT?	Was there a **purpose**, and were there specific applications for the listeners?
Was the sermon CLEAR?	Was there good explanation and a clear **structure** that was easy to follow? Was the communication good?

Evaluate yourself: Do this first, as you prepare and practice. Are you clear on what you are preaching, why you are preaching it and how you are delivering it? If not, there is a problem.

Get others to evaluate you: Allow others to give constructive criticism at the appropriate moment after the sermon using the questions above. You might want to ask someone in advance to do this. When you are evaluating people always begin with some genuine encouragement. It may be best to only give encouragement straight afterwards and to then offer further constructive criticism later on.

13.4 CONCLUSION: PULLING IT ALL TOGETHER

13.4.1 Ezekiel 37:1-14 and the breath of God

On the next page there is a table that will help you pull together the findings for 2 Tim 1:6-7 from the work we have done. We will use a similar table throughout the rest of the curriculum.

But to conclude this unit we will look at Ezekiel 37:1-14 and the powerful picture it contains.

- Before you read it together as a group read the following notes:

  Ezekiel is a prophet and is called to preach to Israel. However, the message of Ezekiel 37 is not mainly about the work of a preacher. Ezekiel 37 is a vision of Israel being resurrected and restored by God after the punishment of the Exile.

  But Ezekiel is commanded to preach or prophesy to the bones in this vision, and, in the context of Scripture Sculpture, it is a powerful picture of flesh and skeleton, heart and brain, skin and bones coming together.

  Without the breath of God, the Spirit of God, the bones will remain bones. We need to pray throughout the process of preparing to preach and ask God the Holy Spirit, who inspired the Scriptures, to breathe his new life into our preaching and through it, into the lives of our listeners.

- Now read Ezekiel 37:1-14 with this background in mind.

In the context of the Pastoral Epistles, Paul tells Timothy to guard the gospel “with the help of the Holy Spirit who lives in us” (2 Tim 1:14). God longs to use us to guard the gospel, not least as we preach and teach, and he gives us the strength of his Holy Spirit to empower us for that task.

- End this unit with prayer for one another in this important area.

13.4.2 Preaching the message of 2 Tim 1:6-7

Use the table below to record the key ideas we have discussed for a sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):